

ILLUSTRATIVE CONSULTING CASE · UK HIGH STREETS

Fixing Northbridge's high street

A five-year plan to bring town-centre shop vacancy down from 18% to the GB average of 14% by 2030

Mohammadamin Zare · October 2026

Northbridge is an illustrative composite town; all data is real and public

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Shopping alone will not refill Northbridge: shrink the retail core and give people other reasons to come

> Northbridge should concentrate retail into a compact core, fill empty units fast using its new powers, and anchor the centre with food, leisure and homes.

PILLAR 1

Right-size the centre

27.5% of retail spending is now online and isn't coming back. Struggling towns have **more than twice** the retail space per person of thriving ones.

PILLAR 2

Fill empty units fast

High Street Rental Auctions let the council let units empty for a year **without landlord consent**. Independents, **84%** of closures, face a **28%** rates rise in 2026/27.

PILLAR 3

Give people reasons to come

In thriving centres food is **£1 in every £4** spent, against £1 in £10 in struggling ones. A food and leisure anchor, events and town-centre homes bring footfall back.

Sources: ONS; Centre for Retail Research; BRC–Local Data Company; Centre for Cities; England business rates 2024–2027. Full list on the last slide.

THE QUESTION

We turned "what do we do about the high street?" into one answerable question

> How can Northbridge Council bring town-centre shop vacancy down from about 18% to 14% by 2030, while increasing footfall, using its existing powers and about £5m of capital?

✓ Specific ✓ Measurable ✓ Action-oriented ✓ Relevant ✓ Time-bound

DECISION-MAKER

Council leader and cabinet, who need a fundable plan with visible results within 12 months.

IN SCOPE

- Town-centre units
- Planning, rental auctions, grants
- Council property, events, parking

OUT OF SCOPE

- National tax policy (taken as given)
- Out-of-town retail parks
- Online retail itself

Northbridge's 18% vacancy matches the North East average (17.9%, Q4 2023, Local Data Company). GB average 14.0%.

APPROACH

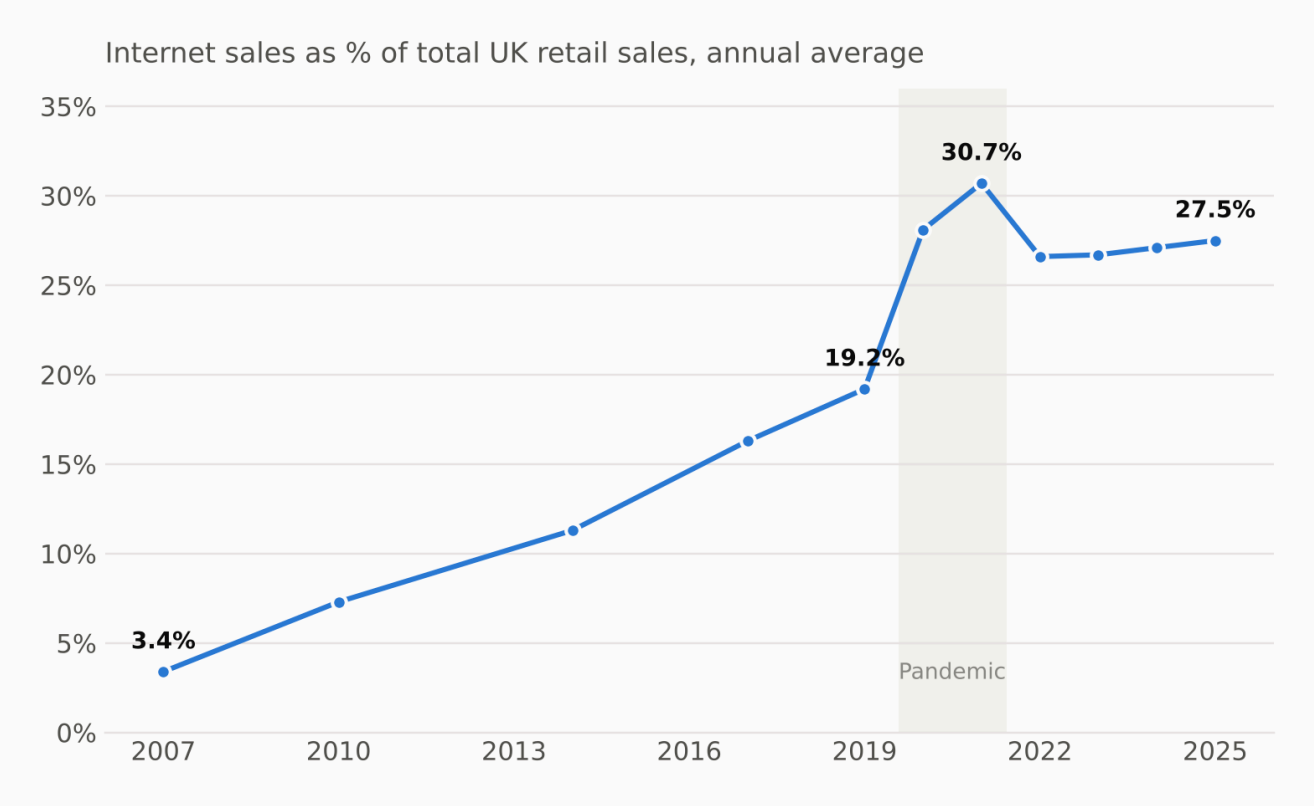
We tested eight hypotheses across four MECE branches; two were wrong, and that changed the answer

How can Northbridge cut vacancy from ~18% to 14% by 2030?

A. Demand: enough customers?	✓ SUPPORTED The shift online is structural	✓ SUPPORTED Footfall is still falling
B. Supply: right space?	✓ SUPPORTED Struggling towns have too much retail space	✓ SUPPORTED Convenient formats win; high streets lag
C. Cost: can occupiers afford it?	✕ REFUTED The 2026 rates reform lowers small shops' costs	✕ REFUTED Chains leaving is the main cause of closures
D. Activation: is anyone filling units?	✓ SUPPORTED The council has new powers to fill empty units	✓ SUPPORTED Strong centres draw people with food and leisure

Each branch is one reason a unit stays empty: too few customers, wrong space, too costly, or nobody filling it. Every unit falls into exactly one.

More than a quarter of retail spending is now online, and most of the pandemic jump has stuck



72%

of the pandemic jump in online share has stuck: 19.2% in 2019, 30.7% in 2021, 27.5% in 2025

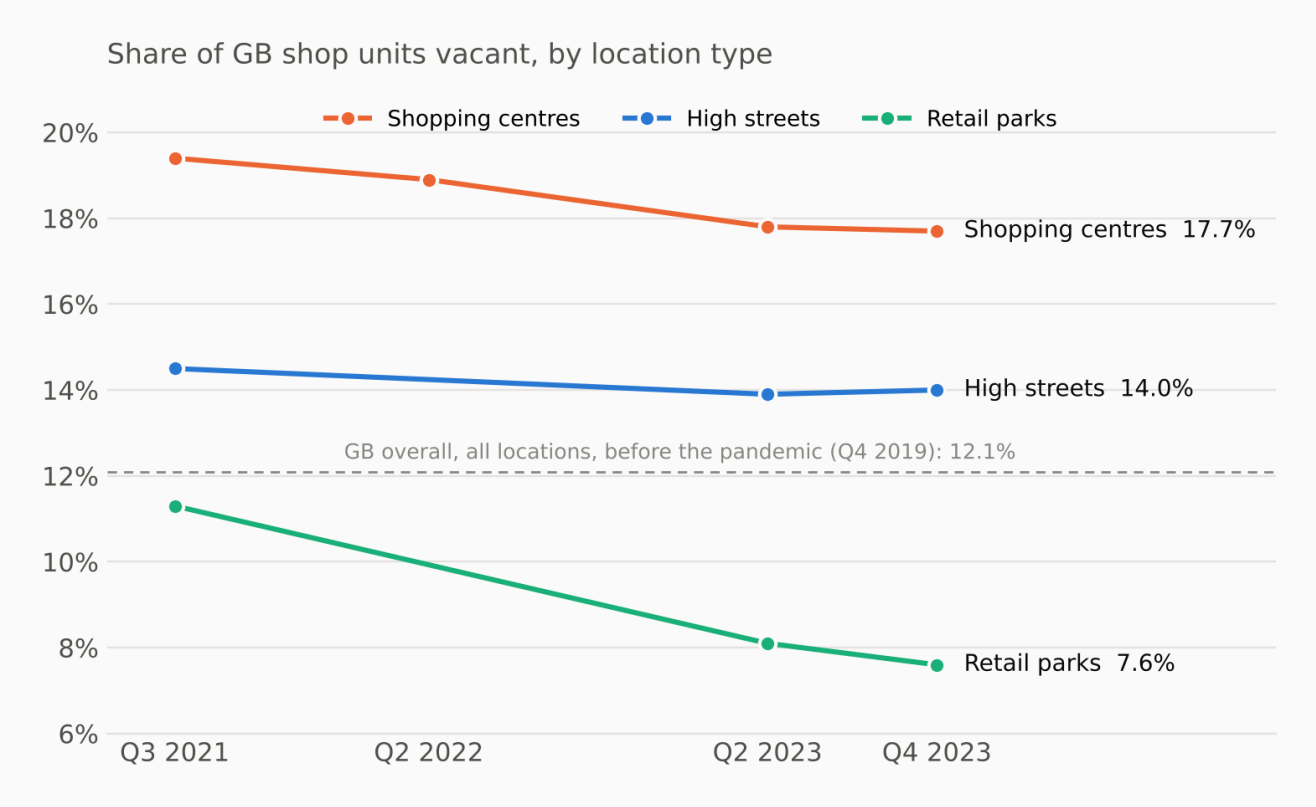
- Footfall is still drifting down: **−0.8%** across 2025, **−2.9%** in December
- The spending that left is not coming back to physical shops

SO WHAT

Northbridge needs reasons to visit that the internet can't replace.

Source: ONS Retail Sales Index, series J4MC; BRC–Sensormatic footfall monitor (9 Jan 2026).

Retail parks recovered after the pandemic; high streets did not, and struggling towns simply have too much space



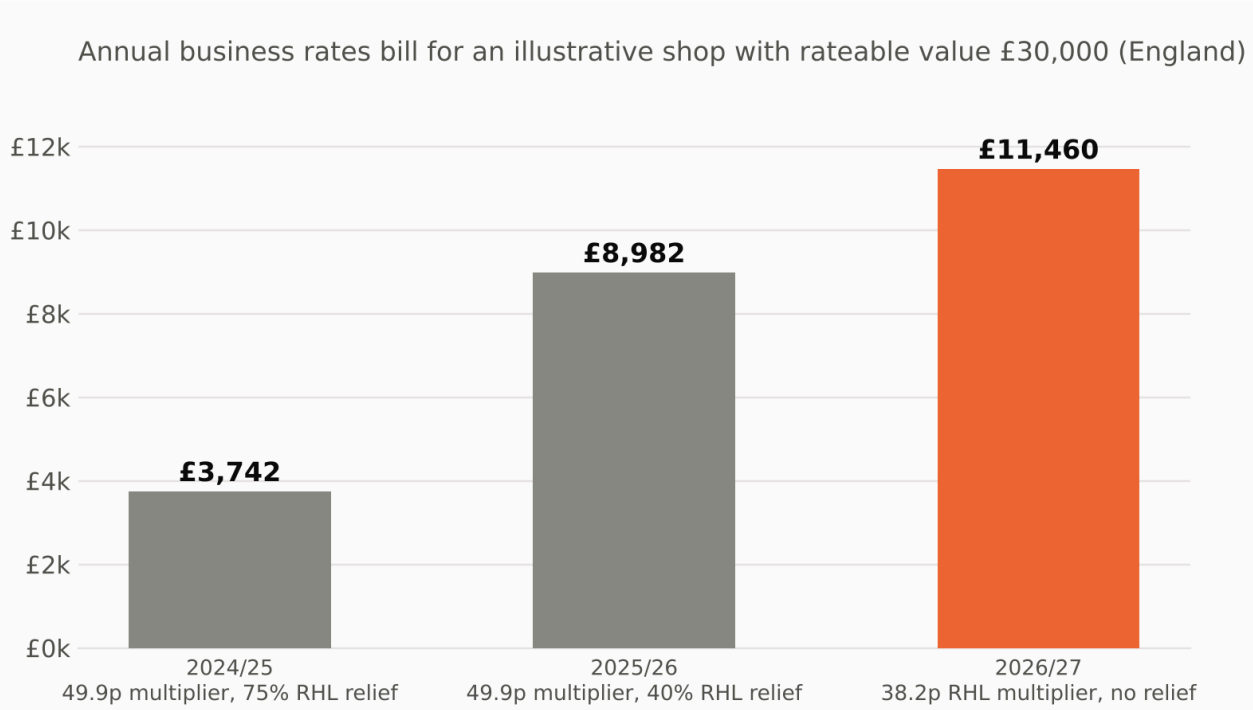
- Retail park vacancy fell from **11.3% to 7.6%**; high streets barely moved (**14.5% → 14.0%**)
- Newport, Wigan and Middlesbrough have **more than twice the retail space per person** of Brighton or Liverpool
- North East vacancy (**17.9%**) is almost **70% higher** than London's (10.6%)

SO WHAT

Even a successful plan won't fill every unit as a shop. Shrink the retail footprint and repurpose the rest.

Source: BRC–Local Data Company Vacancy Monitor (Q3 2021–Q4 2023); Centre for Cities, Checking out (July 2025).

The "permanent cut" in business rates still raises a small shop's bill by 28% in 2026/27



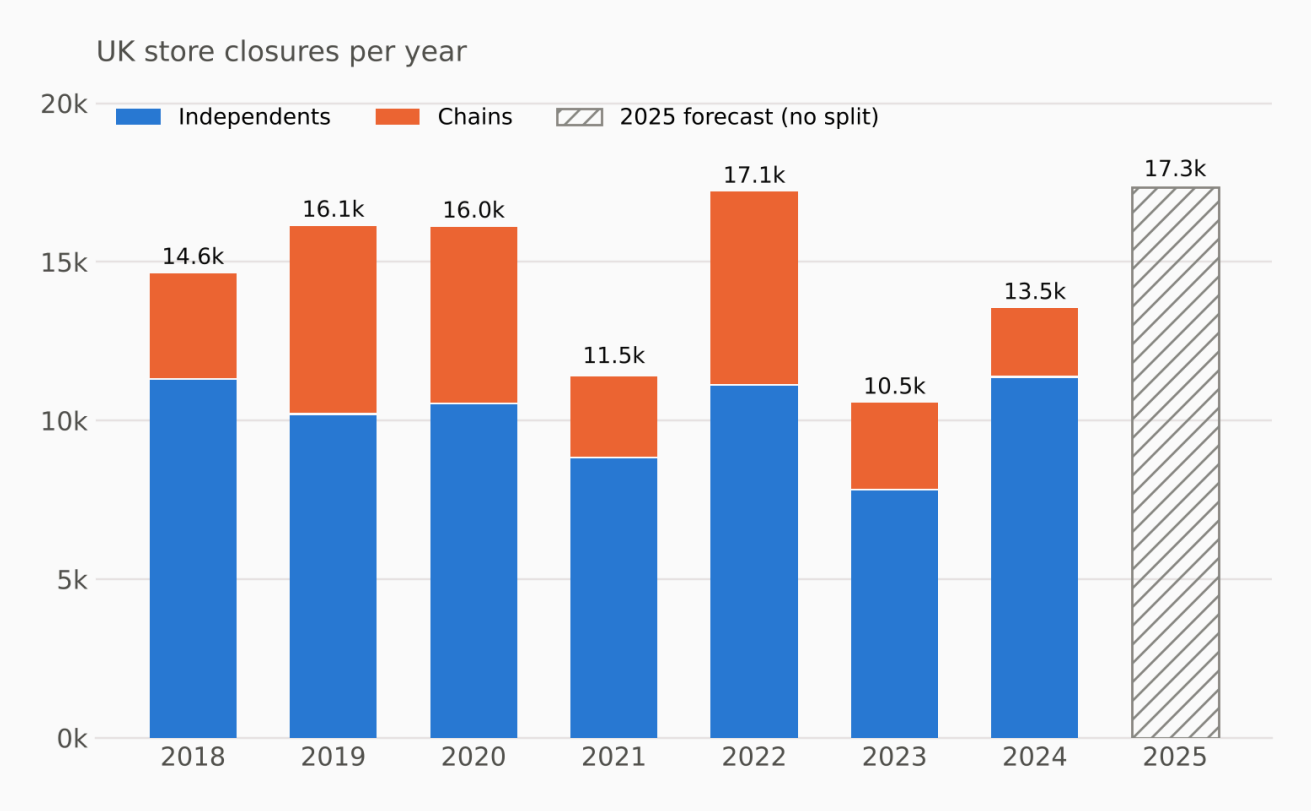
- From April 2026, a new lower multiplier (**38.2p**) replaces the **40% relief** retail had in 2025/26
- For a shop with a rateable value of £30,000, the bill rises from **£8,982 to £11,460**, three times its 2024/25 level
- This hypothesis was **refuted**: rates are not a problem already solved by government

SO WHAT

A one-year rates transition grant keeps viable independents open through the cliff.

Source: Armstrong Watson (May 2025); Spelthorne Borough Council 2026/27 multipliers. Illustrative: ignores the 2026 revaluation and transitional relief.

Independents, not chains, now account for 5 in 6 store closures



84%

of 2024's 13,479 closures were independents (11,341)

- Chain closures peaked in 2019, 2020 and 2022, and have fallen since
- About **17,350** closures were forecast for 2025, up 29% on 2024

SO WHAT

Keeping the independents already there matters as much as attracting national chains.

Source: Centre for Retail Research (2018–2024 actual; 2025 forecast).

RECOMMENDATIONS

Three pillars: right-size the centre, fill empty units fast, and give people reasons to come

PILLAR 1

Right-size the centre

- Define a compact retail core of 2–3 streets
- Rezone the edges for homes, health, education and workspace
- Start conversions with council-owned property

Because: too much retail space for the spending left (findings A, B)

PILLAR 2

Fill empty units fast

- High Street Rental Auctions on units empty more than a year
- Meanwhile-use and pop-up programme
- 2026/27 rates transition grant for small independents

Because: new powers exist, and independents face a rates cliff (findings C, D)

PILLAR 3

Give people reasons to come

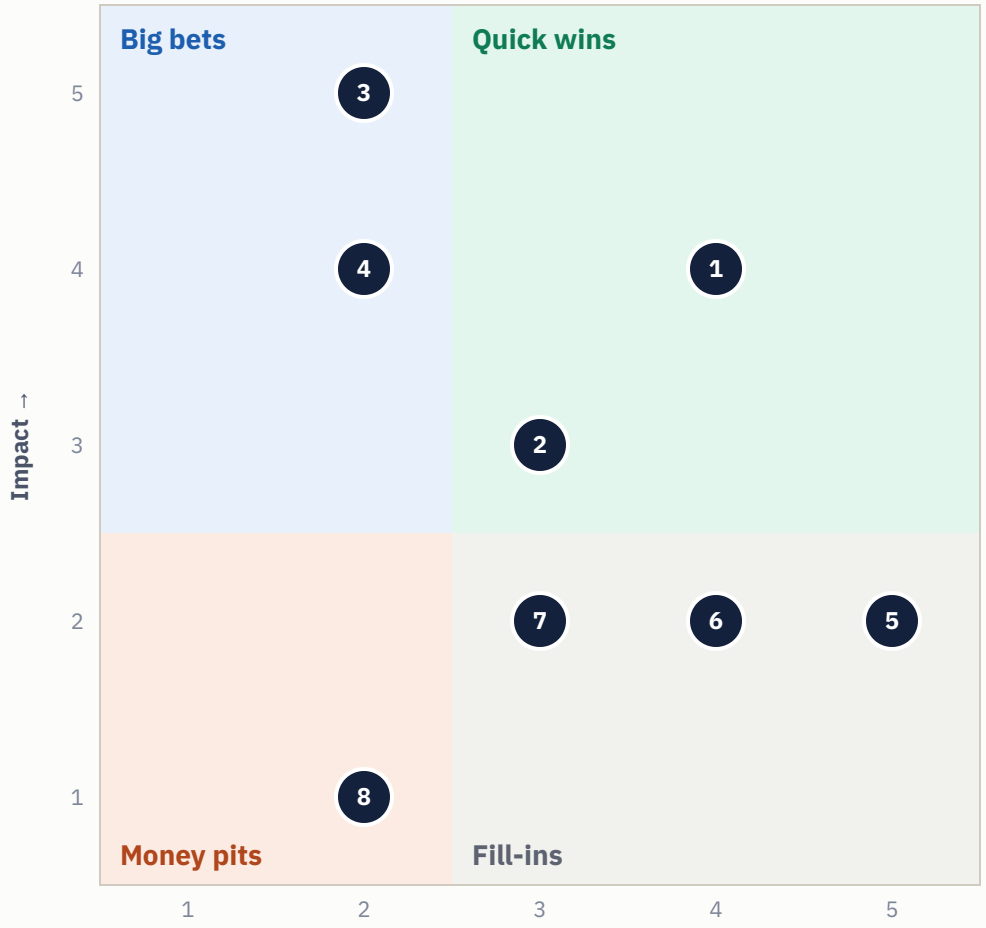
- A food and leisure anchor, such as a market hall in a large empty unit
- A year-round events programme
- Prioritise new homes in the town centre

Because: strong centres win on food, leisure and residents (findings A, D)

Recommendations draw on Centre for Cities (2025) and the High Street Rental Auction regulations (in force 2 December 2024).

PRIORITISATION

Two quick wins to start now, two big bets to fund over five years, and free parking dropped



#	OPTION	I	E	QUADRANT
1	High Street Rental Auctions	4	4	Quick win
2	Rates transition grant	3	3	Quick win
3	Shrink the core, convert the edges	5	2	Big bet
4	Food and leisure anchor	4	2	Big bet
5	Meanwhile use and pop-ups	2	5	Fill-in
6	Town-centre data dashboard	2	4	Fill-in
7	Year-round events	2	3	Fill-in
8	Free parking	1	2	Money pit

I = impact on the 18% → 14% target; E = ease (cost, speed, council control). Scores are team judgement on a 1–5 scale; 3 or more counts as high.

ROADMAP

Visible results in year one, the big bets in years one to three, and 14% vacancy by 2030

First 12 months

- Launch the town-centre dashboard
- Designate the auction area; run the first 5–10 auctions
- Start the pop-up programme
- Open the rates transition grant

Vacancy down 1–2 points

Years 1–3

- Adopt the masterplan: retail core plus conversion zones
- Open the food and leisure anchor
- Begin council-led conversions

Footfall above the 2025 baseline

Years 3–5

- Deliver conversions to homes and services
- Match the retail footprint to demand

Vacancy at 14% by 2030

Town-centre vacancy	Persistent vacancy (2+ years)	Footfall (2025 = 100)	Food, leisure and services share of units	New homes in the centre
18% → 14%	Halved	> 100	+10 pts	Set in plan

Baselines for persistent vacancy and unit mix to be set by a unit-by-unit survey in the first three months.

RISKS AND NEXT STEPS

The main risks are landlord resistance and capital; both have clear mitigations

RISK	MITIGATION
Landlords resist auctions or conversions	Start with the longest-empty units, publish the data, offer partnership before compulsory powers
£5m is too little for conversions	Use council property first; bid for national regeneration funding; joint ventures with housing associations
Pop-ups don't become lasting tenants	Track conversion to longer leases; give successful pop-ups priority in auctions
National policy changes again	Review the rates grant yearly; build the plan on demand and supply, not tax

NEXT STEPS

- **Cabinet:** agree the core boundary and auction area
- **Month 1–3:** unit-by-unit vacancy survey to set baselines
- **Within 6 months:** first rental auction, to show early results

SOURCES

All figures come from public sources

Online share of retail. ONS Retail Sales Index, series J4MC (internet sales as % of total retail sales), annual averages; release of 22 May 2026 as reported by Eightx.

Store closures and job losses. Centre for Retail Research, 2018–2024 actual and 2025 forecast, via Insight DIY (31 Dec 2024).

Vacancy by location and region. BRC–Local Data Company Vacancy Monitor, Q3 2021–Q4 2023, via Insight DIY, Bira, Furniture News and Green Street News.

Footfall. BRC–Sensormatic IQ footfall monitor, published 9 January 2026.

Business rates, England. Retail, hospitality and leisure relief 2024/25–2025/26 (Armstrong Watson, May 2025); 2026/27 multipliers (Spelthorne Borough Council).

Retail space, spending mix, policy. Centre for Cities, *Checking out: the varying performance of high streets across the country* (July 2025), via Specification Online.

High Street Rental Auctions. In force in England from 2 December 2024 (Trowers & Hamlins summary).

About this case. Northbridge is an illustrative composite town, not a real client. Figures from secondary reports should be checked against the original publisher before formal use. Independent project; not affiliated with any consultancy.

Links to every source: analysis/data/SOURCES.md in the GitHub repository.